

NETWORK WORLD NEWSLETTER: MIKE KARP
on STORAGE IN THE ENTERPRISE
10/18/01 - Today's focus: Agreeing on the same thing

Dear Wincenty Kaminski,

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Today's focus: Agreeing on the same thing

By Mike Karp

Storage Resource Management is a term much like "virtualization" because both have almost as many definitions as there are people talking about the subject. That's why when my friend Anne and I talk to vendors and they bring up the topic of SRM, one of the first questions we typically ask is "What do you mean by SRM?"

Now Anne and I are both reasonable people (I much more so than she, of course), so we aren't looking for any particular "right" answer, and the question certainly isn't part of a litmus test. The SRM question is just a way of calibrating the vendor in terms of its outlook on the storage world, and that usually turns out to be a useful exercise for both parties. Sometimes we uncover silliness, but usually we find that the vendors have given at least some critical thought to this subject, and often they are better able to focus the discussion on the subset of SRM that is their company's strength.

Sometimes vendors really miss the boat however, and occasionally this takes place in just the wrong forum. At a recent storage conference for instance, one vendor's presentation identified "The Five Aspects of SRM." This quite logically included the topics of backup and archiving. Unfortunately, nowhere in the slide set was there any mention of recovery, which is of course is the only reason for backing up and archiving (unless you are selling tape drives and media, in which case backing up for the sake of backing up makes perfect sense). This point was not lost on the audience sitting

in front of me, whose private conversations proved once again what many of you have known all along: towards the end of the day, when hunger increases and the blood sugar lowers, senior IT managers are no kinder than the rest of us.

The fix for this sort of thing is both simple and obvious. No writer ever edits his own work. No scientific paper ever goes to press without having undergone a process of peer-review before publication. In like fashion, it makes little sense for products to be planned or for presentations to be brought before the public (or even before the venture capital community) without some sort of critical analysis by a relatively unbiased third party. Analyst firms offer these services, and for smaller companies so do high tech incubators and the various venture capital forums that are still very active in the more technology-centric areas such as Silicon Valley, Cambridge and Austin.

Don't like these suggestions? Then at least go to someone within your own company - someone, I might add, who wasn't involved in building the presentation - for a reality check. You may be pleasantly surprised by the insights some of your junior engineers have to offer.

Editor's Note: In last week's newsletter headlined "Taking a Swiss approach to storage," the correct reference to NAS is Network-Attached Storage.

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